



Gold hunt: Newly appointed T20I captain Shreyas Iyer will lead the squad in Japan, with Tilak Varma as his deputy. AFP

Winning the present, building the future

India will defend its Asian Games cricket titles in Japan, but the tournament also offers a **crucial glimpse** into the teams being built for Los Angeles 2028.

Shayan Acharya
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

For Indian cricket, the Asian Games in Japan is no longer just about defending two gold medals.

It comes at an important point in India's T20 cycle, with cricket returning to the Olympics at Los Angeles 2028 and the Games offering another look at the players and combinations that could shape its teams over the next

two years.

The men's team is considerably stronger than the one sent to Hangzhou, where India fielded a largely second-string side. Shreyas Iyer will lead a squad featuring Jasprit Bumrah, Sanju Samson, Abhishek Sharma, Tilak Varma, Axar Patel, Arshdeep Singh and Washington Sundar, among others. Fifteen-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, whose emergence has already attracted considerable attention, is also in the group.

For Shreyas, the Asian Games is an important early assignment as India's T20 captain: leading a side expected to win while getting a better sense of the players who could form its core going forward. Sooryavanshi, Abhishek and Tilak, in particular, have an opportunity to strengthen

TOTAL MEDALS AT STAKE

6